



In the Haitian Revolution, slaves fought in a series of battles with French troops (shown here), as well as with British and Spanish colonialists, between 1791 and 1804.

won a settlement of land. In the French colony of Saint-Domingue on the western end of the island of Hispaniola, slaves began an armed revolt in 1791. Toussaint L'Ouverture, a freed slave and skillful soldier, played a leading role in the struggle for control of Saint-Domingue and its neighbor, Santo Domingo (later the Dominican Republic).

The uprisings eventually won Saint-Domingue, now called Haiti, its independence from France in 1804, making it the first country to be governed by former slaves. These early slave revolts inspired other slaves in the Caribbean to take agency in the fight for freedom.

Parliament's ban

From 1787, British parliamentarian William Wilberforce became a leading abolitionist and strove for 20 years to bring anti-slavery bills before Parliament. Despite great public support, politicians were unwilling to vote for an outright ban on slavery, fearing it would harm British business interests.

In 1806, abolitionist James Stephen advised Wilberforce to change tack and introduce a bill to stop Britons from trading slaves with foreign territories. As Britain was at war with France, the bill was presented as a patriotic effort to harm French interests and was passed. However, as Wilberforce hoped, it caused a collapse in the British slave trade and paved the way for the 1807 Abolition of the Slave Trade Act. Passed with a majority of 114 to 15 in the House of Commons, the 1807 Act made it illegal to engage in slave trading in the British Empire or to carry slaves in any British ship, but did not compel the freeing of all slaves. That became the goal of the next phase of the abolition campaign.

The Royal Navy patrolled the coast of Africa to enforce the ban on trading slaves. Between 1807 and 1860, it stopped many British vessels and liberated over 150,000 slaves, but enforcing the Act was a huge task. Rogue British merchants often evaded it by operating under other countries' flags.

Despite widespread public support for abolition, Parliament did not allow an outright ban on slavery until the 1830s. The economic climate had changed: British-run Caribbean sugar plantations were now much less profitable than those in Brazil and Cuba. So British merchants pressed for free trade and an end to the Caribbean monopoly of the British sugar market.

The 1833 Slavery Abolition Act freed only those aged under 6 years; older slaves became “apprentices,” compelled to work for their former owners for a number of years. The territories controlled by the British East India Company—for example, Ceylon (now Sri Lanka)—were also exempt, but slavery was otherwise outlawed across the British Empire.

America and slavery

Slavery was key to the economy of the Southern colonies of the US, where slaves were used to do the grueling work on plantations of cotton and other cash crops that »

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A trade founded in iniquity, and carried on as this was, must be abolished ...

William Wilberforce
Speech to Parliament, 1789

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